old universal time and carry it with us. It becomes our own personal clock, our own personal lead relentlessly pulling us from one moment to the next. We are shocked by the theories of relativity, by the universe that is, because while our personal clock seems to tick away uniformly, in concert with our intuitive sense of time, comparison with other clocks reveals differences. Time for you need not be the same as time for me.

Let's accept that lesson as a given. But what *is* the true nature of time for me? What is the full character of time as experienced and conceived by the individual, without primary focus on comparisons with the experiences of others? Do these experiences accurately reflect the true nature of time? And what do they tell us about the nature of reality?

Our experiences teach us, overwhelmingly so, that the past is different from the future. The future seems to present a wealth of possibilities, while the past is bound to one thing, the fact of what actually happened. We feel able to influence, to affect, and to mold the future to one degree or another, while the past seems immutable. And in between *past* and *future* is the slippery concept of *now,* a temporal holding point that reinvents itself moment to moment, like the frames in a movie film as they sweep past the projector's intense light beam and become the momentary present. Time seems to march to an endless, perfectly uniform rhythm, reaching the fleeting destination of *now* with every beat of the drummer's stick.

Our experiences also teach us that there is an apparent lopsidedness to how things unfold in time. There is no use crying over spilled milk, because once spilled it can never be unspilled: we never see splattered milk gather itself together, rise off the floor, and coalesce in a glass that sets itself upright on a kitchen counter. Our world seems to adhere perfectly to a one-way temporal arrow, never deviating from the fixed stipulation that things can start like *this* and end like *that,* but they can never start like *that* and end like *this.*

Our experiences, therefore, teach us two overarching things about time. First, *time seems to flow.* It's as if we stand on the riverbank of time as the mighty current rushes by, sweeping the future toward us, becoming *now* at the moment it reaches us, and rushing onward as it recedes downstream into the past. Or, if that is too passive for your taste,